

ECON 488

Radical Political Economy

Fall 2026

UMKC - Department of Economics

 **Instructor:** Kabeer Bora

 **Department:** Economics

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 **Term begins:** August 2026

 **Location:** Royall Hall, Rm 00213

 **Meets:** Mon & Wed, 2:00–3:15 pm

 **Office:** Mann 203E

 **Office Hours:** Tue & Thu, 2:00–4:00 pm

Course Description & Learning Outcomes

This course explores the fundamental concepts of Marxian and classical political economy, and their bearing on philosophy, sociology, and political science as they relate to Karl Marx's writings. The primary focus is on critically analyzing Marxist and classical economics: value and surplus value, accumulation, distribution, class, and crisis. Where useful, we supply historical context from the history of economic thought. Towards the end, we apply Marxian economics to international trade and the world economy.

Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion of this course, students should be able to:

- ✓ Develop a detailed understanding of the fundamentals of Marxian economic theory,
- ✓ Acquire familiarity with key Marxian variables (value, surplus value, the rate of profit) and their quantitative assessment,
- ✓ Apply Marxian economic theory to analyze real-world events empirically,
- ✓ Critically read and evaluate value-theoretic arguments — from the labour theory of value to the transformation problem and unequal exchange,
- ✓ Effectively communicate economic content through written work and oral presentations.

Required & Supplementary Materials

Primary Text

-  **The Logic of Capital: An Introduction to Marxist Economic Theory** by Deepankar Basu (2021, Cambridge University Press) — *our spine throughout the semester.*

Recommended Supplements

- › Rieu, Dong-Min. *A Mathematical Approach to Marxian Value Theory* (2022).
- › Tsoulfidis, Lefteris & Persefoni Tsaliki. *Classical Political Economics and Modern Capitalism* (2019).
- › Wolff, Richard & Stephen Resnick. *New Departures in Marxian Theory* (2006) — for the class and overdetermination material.
- › Emmanuel (1972); Amin (1976); Shaikh & Tonak (1994) — for productive/unproductive labour and unequal exchange.

Additional readings will be flagged in class as needed, and PDFs posted to Canvas.

Tentative Course Outline

This is a provisional outline for our Monday/Wednesday meetings. I will assess our progress as we go; the heavier mathematical topics (production & money, technical change, the transformation problem) may spill across weeks.

Week 1 (August) — Marx's Life, Philosophy & Method

Readings: Basu Ch. 2; Wolff & Resnick, Part I (overview)

Topics: Historical materialism and base/superstructure vs. overdetermination; why we study the “logic” of capital.

Week 2 (August) — Introduction to the Labor Theory of Value

Readings: Basu Ch. 3.1; Rieu Ch. 2; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 1.3–1.4

Topics: The commodity, use-value and exchange-value, concrete vs. abstract labour, socially necessary labour time, the homogenization and socialization of labour.

September — Labor Day (Mon, Sep 7)

No class. We meet Wednesday only this week.

Week 3 (September) — A Model of Production & Marx on Money

Readings: Basu Ch. 3.1.5 & 3.2; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 1.5–1.6

Topics: The corn model ($\lambda = l/(1 - a)$); complexity, productivity and intensity. Where money comes from: the four value-forms, MELT, and $MV = PQ$.

Week 4 (September) — Generation of Surplus Value

Readings: Basu Ch. 3.3 & 3.4; Rieu Ch. 4; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 1.7

Topics: $M-C-M'$, labour-power as a commodity, absolute vs. relative surplus value, intensity, formal vs. real subsumption, the evolution of production.

Week 5 (September) — Accumulation of Capital

 **Readings:** Basu Ch. 3.5 & 3.6

 **Topics:** Simple vs. expanded reproduction, the reserve army of labour, concentration and centralization, primary (“primitive”) accumulation.

Weeks 6 & 7 (Sep–Oct) — Realization of Surplus Value

 **Readings:** Basu Ch. 4.1–4.3; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 2.4–2.6

 **Topics:** The circuit of capital and its three forms, turnover, the aggregate-demand (realization) problem, Departments I & II and the reproduction schemes.

October — Fall Break (Thursday–Sunday)

Fall break falls Oct 8–11 (Thu–Sun), so it does not cancel any of our Monday/Wednesday meetings.

Week 8 (October) — Distribution of Surplus Value

 **Readings:** Basu Ch. 5.1–5.3; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 4

 **Topics:** Prices of production and the average rate of profit ($\bar{r} = 22\%$), rate of exploitation vs. rate of surplus value, the falling rate of profit and Okishio, commercial profit.

Week 9 (October) — Productive & Unproductive Labour

 **Readings:** Basu Ch. 5.4 & 5.5; Savran & Tonak (1999); Shaikh & Tonak (1994)

 **Topics:** What creates value vs. what only moves it; can unproductive workers be exploited?; interest and fictitious capital.

Week 10 (October) — Class: Poulantzas, Roemer, Wright & Resnick–Wolff

 **Readings:** Wolff & Resnick, Part I, Ch. 1–2; class-theory guides; U.S. ACS data

 **Topics:** Four theories of class; class as position vs. class as process; dividing the U.S. workforce with real Census data.

Week 11 (November) — Ground Rent

 **Readings:** Basu Ch. 5.6; Marx, *Capital* Vol. III, Part VI

 **Topics:** Rent as surplus profit (the waterfall), differential rent (DR I & II) and absolute rent, land price as capitalized rent.

Week 12 (November) — Capitalism & Technical Change

 **Readings:** Basu Ch. 6; Rieu Ch. 7

 **Topics:** Viability vs. progressiveness, types of technical change, Okishio’s theorem and the Marx–Okishio threshold. (*No class Wed, Nov 11 — Veterans’ Day; we meet Monday only.*)

Week 13 (November) — The Transformation Problem (begins)

 **Readings:** Basu Ch. 7; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 3

 **Topics:** Marx’s two claims and Böhm-Bawerk’s two mistakes; the Standard Interpretation and invariance principles.

Week 14 (November) — Thanksgiving Week Break (Nov 23–29)

 **No class** (Mon Nov 23 & Wed Nov 25).

Week 15 (December) — The Transformation Problem (concludes)

 **Readings:** Basu Ch. 7 (cont.)

 **Topics:** Sraffa's critique ("are values redundant?"), the Fundamental Marxian Theorem, and the New Interpretation.

Week 16 (December) — Unequal Exchange in International Trade

 **Readings:** Emmanuel (1972); Amin (1976); Ricci (2019, 2021); Basu Ch. 3.2.7

 **Topics:** Comparative advantage vs. the value drain; Emmanuel's mechanism; Amin's autcentric vs. ex-traverted accumulation and imperial rent; Ricci and the value of money.

Tentative Evaluation & Grading

 **Important:** It is your responsibility to follow emails and announcements sent through **Canvas**, and to stay up to date with the deadlines and course material.

Assignments

 **In-Class Weekly Tests (20%)** — a short in-person quiz at the start of most weeks, consisting of 2-3 questions on the material covered the previous week (not multiple-choice). These are open-book and straightforward but require effort. Your lowest score is dropped.

 **Presentations & Discussant (40%)** — the class includes student presentations in groups (frequency set by enrolment; sign-ups in the first week). Each presenter is paired with a **discussant** who summarises the presentation and invites clarifying questions. *Presenter 30% + Discussant 10%.*

 **Applied Final Paper (40%)** — an end-of-semester essay that uses Marxian theory as a tool to examine a real-world question (e.g. the gender wage gap, inequality in the Global South, the political economy of an industry or state). The focus is practical application: articulate the Marxian variables and build a compelling, evidence-based narrative.

Grading Scale

Percentage of Points Earned	Letter Grade Earned
93-100%	A
90-92%	A-
87-89%	B+
83-86%	B
80-82%	B-
77-79%	C+
73-76%	C
70-72%	C-
67-69%	D+
63-66%	D
60-62%	D-
0-59%	F

! Late Assignments

All assignments are administered through Canvas, configured to reject submissions after the deadline — *no* late assignments, exams, or projects are accepted. Stay on top of the due dates on your class calendar. Active, regular participation is crucial for success.

🍴 Basic Needs

It can be challenging to do your best in class if you have trouble meeting basic needs like safe shelter, sleep, and nutrition. If you have difficulty affording groceries or accessing sufficient food to eat every day, or lack a safe and stable place to live, UMKC is here to help.

🏠 **UMKC Basic Needs:** [Basic Needs webpage](#) — Information on food assistance, housing assistance, and financial literacy.

🐨 **Kangaroo Pantry:** [Kangaroo Pantry website](#) — Free food and other items for all UMKC students.

👉 I strongly encourage you to set up an appointment with UMKC Basic Needs and/or me if you have a need for this type of assistance.

📅 Academic Calendar

Students are encouraged to review important add, drop or withdraw dates in the [UMKC Academic Calendar](#) site.

Date	Description
August 24	Classes Begin (full 16-week session) — <i>our first meeting</i>
August 28	Last day to register without paying a late registration fee; last day to change a course from Audit to Credit
September 4	Last day to add courses without an instructor signature; last day for a 100% refund
September 7	Labor Day Holiday (University Closed) — no class
September 21	Census Day. Last day to drop a course and not have it appear on your transcript; last day for a 50% refund; last day to change a course from Credit to Audit
October 1	Spring 2027 Priority Registration begins
October 8–11	Fall Break (Thursday–Sunday). <i>Our Mon/Wed meetings are unaffected</i>
October 16	Last day for a 25% refund. Last day to withdraw with a “W” (graduate — full 16-week session)
October 26	Spring 2027 Open Registration begins
October 31	Deadline to apply for Fall 2026 graduation
November 11	Veterans’ Day Holiday (University Closed) — a Wednesday; no class for ECON 488
November 13	Last day to withdraw with a “W” (undergraduate — full 16-week session)
November 23–29	Thanksgiving Week Break — no class Nov 23 & 25
December 11	Last day to withdraw with a “W” or “WF” (graduate/professional). Last day of classes (full 16-week session)

December 12–18	Finals Week (all academic units except Law)
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Table 1: Fall 2026 Academic Schedule. Deadlines shown are for the full 16-week session.

Academic Integrity

The Board of Curators of the University of Missouri recognizes that academic honesty is essential for the intellectual life of the University. Faculty members have a special obligation to expect high standards of academic honesty in all student work. Students have a special obligation to adhere to such standards. Academic dishonesty, including cheating, plagiarism, unauthorized use of artificially generated content, or sabotage, is adjudicated through the University of Missouri Student Conduct Code and Rules of Procedures in Student Conduct Matters.

Academic Support and Mentoring

The department of **Academic Support and Mentoring (ASM)** offers a wide range of services and programs to help students meet their academic goals. ASM offers peer tutoring, writing and presentation assistance, SI study groups, instructional videos and many more resources that are valuable to your success in this class.

-  You can use **RooLearning+** for scheduling appointments and viewing when support for this class is available.
-  Access RooLearning+ by downloading the app from the App Store (Apple) or Google Play (Android) and sign in with your SSO.
-  The URL for the RooLearning+ site is umkc.tedu.app/student.

Attendance Policy

Students are expected to attend and participate in classes as indicated by the course modality (Classroom based, Online, etc. available on [Pathway](#)). For more information on UMKC course modalities, please visit the [Registrar's page](#).

In order to comply with federal regulations associated with eligibility rules for federal financial aid, students not attending/participating in a course during the first three weeks of the term will be administratively dropped from the specific course. Advance notice of attendance policies of academic units and individual instructors should be given, and such notice should be in writing. Students should notify instructors of excused absences in advance, where possible. Students who have an excused absence are expected to make arrangements with instructors for alternative or make-up work. Such arrangements should be made in advance of the absence, where possible. Instructors should accommodate excused absences to the extent that an accommodation can be made that does not unreasonably interfere with the learning objectives of the course or unduly burden the instructor. Attendance policies shall be applied in a non-discriminatory manner. Enrollment as a student is required to attend any class unless otherwise pre-approved by the instructor. Instructors are responsible for verifying student attendance and participation within the first three weeks (16-week course) through the Attendance Verification Survey (administered through UMKC Connect) as well as maintaining records of participation throughout the term so that the last date of attendance for students with recorded "F" or "W" final grades may be submitted.

Campus Safety

Inclement weather, mass notification, and emergency response guide can be found on the [UMKC Alert page](#).

UMKC Connect

Important information is available to undergraduate students in **UMKC Connect**, a central location for faculty, advisors, student services and students to communicate and collaborate on a strategic plan for each student's academic success. Throughout the term, students may receive emails regarding course grades or academic performance. Students should regularly check their Connect dashboard and are expected to address information posted in a timely manner. This information may be shared with the student's Success Network made up of his or her academic advisor(s) and other campus resources so that UMKC may fully support the student's success. Students may schedule appointments to meet with members of their Success Network through UMKC Connect.

Grade Appeal Policy

The University grade appeal procedure is available only for the review of allegedly capricious grading and not for review of the instructor's evaluation of the student's academic performance. Capricious grading, as that term is used here, comprises any of the following:

- The assignment of a grade to a particular student on some basis other than the performance in the course;
- The assignment of a grade to a particular student according to more exacting or demanding standards than were applied to other students in the course; (Note: Additional or different grading criteria may be applied to graduate students enrolled for graduate credit in 300- and 400-level courses.)
- The assignment of a grade by a substantial departure from the instructor's previously announced standards.

Student Accessibility Services and Accommodations

To obtain disability related accommodations and/or auxiliary aids, students with disabilities must contact [Student Accessibility Services](#) as soon as possible by calling 816-235-5612. Once verified, our office will notify the course instructor and outline the accommodation and/or auxiliary aids to be provided. You are also welcomed to contact the Student Accessibility Services office via email at disability@umkc.edu.

Counseling Services and Student Health & Wellness

UMKC students may experience many challenges in their lives while attending college — stress, depression, suicidality, trauma, relationship issues, health concerns, etc. As an institution, we care about your success and well-being, and want to make you aware of some helpful resources on campus.

- **UMKC Counseling Services:** [Counseling Services](#) — Brookside 51 Building, 5110 Oak Street, Suite 201. Appointments: 816-235-1635.
- **UMKC Student Health and Wellness:** [Student Health & Wellness](#) — Brookside 51 Building, 5110 Oak Street, Suite 237. Appointments: 816-235-6133.
- **MindBody Connection:** Student Union, 3rd floor, room 303G & 303H — space for stress relief and mindfulness.
- **UMKC Student HelpLine:** [816-235-2222](tel:816-235-2222) — for any questions or concerns.

Equal Opportunity & Educational Access

UMKC is committed to providing equal opportunities to all students without unlawful discrimination on the basis of a protected identity, including race, color, national origin, ancestry, religion, sex, pregnancy, sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, age, disability, protected veteran status, or any other status protected by applicable state or federal law.

Discrimination & Harassment

Compliance with UM System Collected Rules and Regulations (CRRs) 600.000 is monitored by the [Office of Equity & Title IX](#), but it is the responsibility of the entire university community to provide equal opportunity. If you or someone you know has experienced discrimination or harassment based on their protected identity, we encourage you to visit [Making a Report](#). Most UMKC employees, including instructors, are required reporters; confidential support is available through RISE, Counseling Services, and Student Health & Wellness.

Sexual Harassment under Title IX

UM System Collected Rules and Regulations (CRRs) 600.020 prohibits all students, employees, volunteers, and visitors from engaging in sexual harassment, including sexual assault, dating violence, domestic violence, and stalking, in a university education program or activity against a person in the United States. If you or someone you know has experienced sexual harassment, please visit the [Support and Connections](#) pages of our Equity & Title IX website. For information on how to make a report, visit [Making a Report](#).

Right to Free Expression

It is vitally important for UMKC to foster and maintain an educational environment that promotes free discussion, inquiry and expression by students inside the classroom and beyond, without fear that their exercise of such rights will have negative repercussions. Per UM System CRR 200.015, instructors should encourage free discussion, inquiry, and expression; student performance shall be evaluated solely on an academic basis, not on opinions or conduct in matters unrelated to academic standards. In exercising your right to free expression, UMKC requests students adhere to these guidelines:

- Share responsibility for including all voices in the conversation; listen respectfully and avoid interruptions.
- Recognize how your own identity and experiences inform your opinions; be open to changing your perspective.
- Speak with care, acknowledging that your words may be perceived as marginalizing even when not intended.
- Treat mistakes as valuable in the learning process; channel defensive reactions into productive discussion.
- Differentiate between safety and comfort; accept discomfort as necessary for learning.